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Describe the cause and effect of urbanisation

Cities have become the default home of humanity. Over half of the world's population are already living in urban areas, with the share forecast to climb to 68% by 2050, meaning that another 2.5 billion people will move into cities within three decades (UN-Habitat, 2022). Such a scale of movement has never been seen before. It has been driven by the pull of city jobs, together with the hardships that push farmers away from the countryside, while its consequences now reach the economy, the environment and the health of billions of residents. Therefore, this essay explores the causes of urbanisation driven by the concentration of jobs in cities and rural hardship, discusses how cities concentrate wealth and opportunity, and examines why uncontrolled urban growth overwhelms housing and public services.

Firstly, the concentration of industry and services in cities is a key cause of urbanisation. Young people in rural areas can rarely find employment that matches their education, given that factories, companies and universities are overwhelmingly located in city centres where roads and customers gather. Urban income in developing countries, as noted by the World Bank (2021), is often double or even triple the rural income for the same occupation, a gap which gives village youth a strong push towards the cities. Additionally, the mechanisation of agriculture has eaten steadily into the demand for farm labour. One combine harvester, during the harvest season, can replace dozens of workers, with the displaced villagers heading naturally towards the cities in search of wages.

Secondly, rural hardship, including poverty, conflict and environmental degradation, drives residents away from the countryside. In countries torn by years of conflict such as

Syria and South Sudan, villages and farmland have been destroyed, forcing millions of families to leave their homes, with the majority ending up in urban areas rather than refugee camps (UNHCR, 2022). Meanwhile, farming has become an increasingly hard living across parts of Africa and South Asia, weakened by soil erosion, drought and river pollution. Therefore, many migrants aspire to settle permanently in cities and give their children access to schools and hospitals that their home regions cannot provide, resulting in a steady increase in urban populations. Together, these two pressures explain why the cities keep growing.

Coming to the effects, urbanisation also brings significant economic gains. Cities, by packing workers, capital and knowledge into a small area, allow a division of labour and a degree of cooperation that scattered villages could never manage. City regions, by the common estimates, produce over 80% of the global GDP despite covering less than 3% of the land surface (UN-Habitat, 2022). Migrants reaching cities usually gain higher wages, better education and wider career choices, with the money sent back home supporting the development of their original villages and towns. For instance, remittances sent home by overseas workers and city residents have become a major source of household income in countries like the Philippines, running into tens of billions of dollars each year (World Bank, 2023).

Nevertheless, uncontrolled urban growth puts heavy pressure on housing and public services. More than one billion people currently live in slum districts or self-built housing without safe tap water, proper drains or a legal address, and the figure keeps rising in fast-growing cities of Africa and Asia (UN-Habitat, 2022). The influx of the newcomers also dilutes medical and educational resources, resulting in classrooms packed with

students, roads jammed at all hours and hospitals without enough hands. Air pollution from traffic and factories further weakens residents' lungs over the years, with city air pollution blamed for millions of early deaths every year (WHO, 2022). The pursuit of a better life thus turns, for the poorest newcomers, into a threat to health itself.

In conclusion, urbanisation is primarily driven by the concentration of jobs in cities and by the hardships of rural life. It concentrates wealth and opportunity, lifting the productivity of entire nations, but it also places a significant strain, one that keeps growing, on housing, services and the environment. Despite these concerns, urbanisation itself is not the problem, and the lack of planning is. Governments should therefore invest in secondary cities and rural infrastructure, spreading opportunity more evenly across each country's territory, so that moving to the city becomes a choice rather than a necessity.

Word count: 711

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